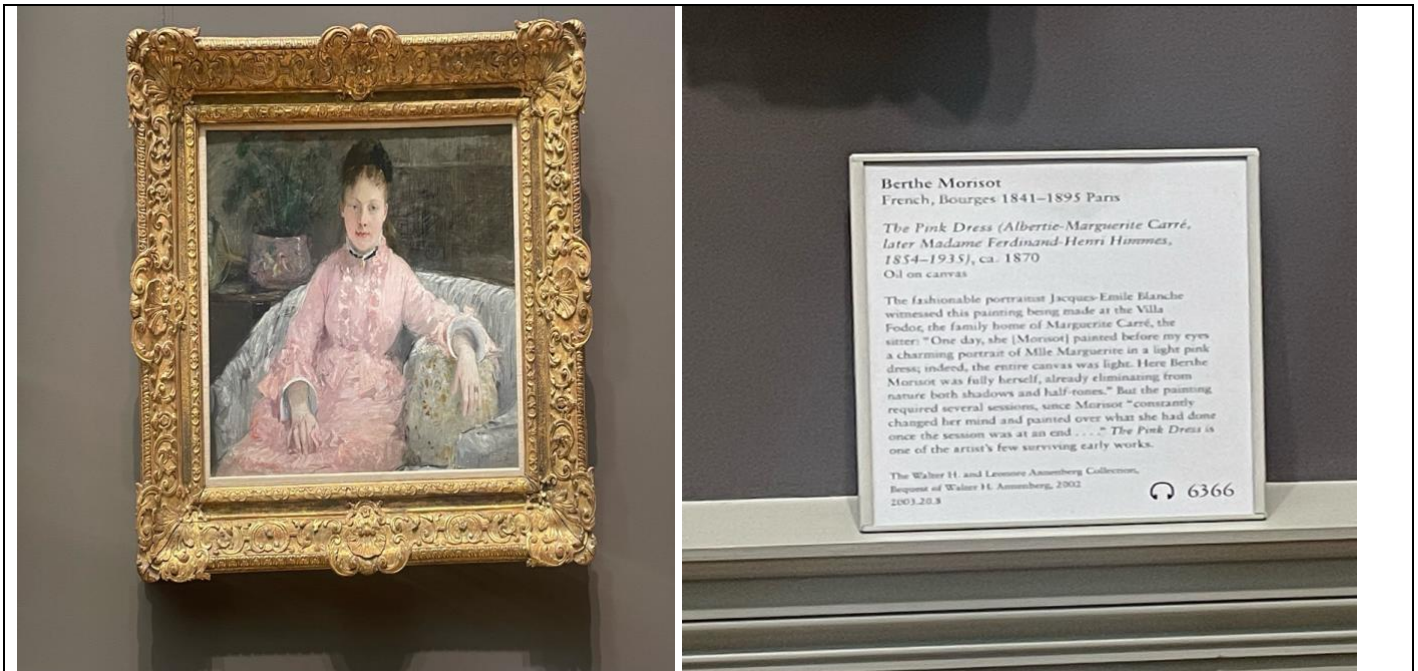


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Masterpieces of Western Art - Written Analysis 2

06/24/2025



Title: The Pink Dress (Albertie-Marguerite Carré, later Madame Ferdinand-Henri Himmes, 1854–1935)

Artist: Berthe Morisot (French, Bourges 1841–1895 Paris)

Date: ca. 1870

Medium: Oil on canvas

Dimensions: 21 1/2 x 26 1/2 in. (54.6 x 67.3 cm)

Classification: Paintings

Credit Line: The Walter H. and Leonore Annenberg Collection, Bequest of Walter H. Annenberg, 2002

Object Number: 2003.20.8¹

¹Morisot Berthe. *The Pink Dress* (1870). The Metropolitan Museum of Art. New York.

<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/438009>. Accessed 22 June 2025

In *The Pink Dress* (1870), Berthe Morisot offers a quietly radical portrayal of modern femininity. Displayed in Gallery 821 at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, this early Impressionist painting depicts Marguerite Carré not simply as a fashionable subject, but as a self-aware individual anchored in her own space and gaze. Far from being a decorative figure, Marguerite emerges as a presence of elegance, agency, and introspection. This analysis argues that Morisot employs light, color, composition, and brushwork to challenge conventional representations of women in art. By refusing to objectify her sitter and instead emphasizing personal identity within a domestic setting, Morisot redefines the visual language of femininity. *The Pink Dress* becomes a site of resistance, subtly yet powerfully asserting women's presence in both public and private realms of artistic expression.

The Pink Dress was painted at Villa Fodor, the home of Marguerite Carré, the sitter. Positioned at the center, Marguerite is seated gracefully on a pale blue upholstered sofa. She wears a voluminous pink gown, while a black ribbon necklace with a small gold pendant contrasts with the light tones of her dress and skin. Her red hair is neatly styled with a small dark accessory. She gazes outward with a calm expression and faint smile. Her delicately painted features, arched brows, and soft lips draw attention to her youthful face. In the background to the left, a round table holds a decorated fan and a pink vase of red flowers, objects that echo the sitter's gown and create visual harmony. Her left arm rests on a gold-trimmed white cushion, a blue ring visible on her ring finger, perhaps hinting at personal or marital identity. Her right hand lies quietly in her lap. The right side of the composition is less detailed, with visible brushstrokes and exposed canvas suggesting spontaneity. This unfinished quality heightens the immediacy of the scene and focuses attention on the sitter. Though the room suggests depth, its indistinct spatiality reflects the Impressionist emphasis on mood over precision. The sketchy background, with its scratch marks

and quick strokes, contrasts with the refined rendering of Marguerite, reinforcing her presence and elegance.

Unlike portraits by male artists that often sexualized their subjects, Morisot's portrayal balances modesty and allure without exposure. Marguerite is fully clothed, but her elegance is expressed through color, posture, and gaze, not through revealed flesh. Her direct look reclaims control over how she is seen, presenting her as a participant in her representation rather than a passive muse. She appears dignified, reflective, and socially poised. Her soft pink gown, often associated with refinement, acts not as mere decoration but as a quiet assertion of self. This aligns with Linda Nochlin's feminist critique that art history has long centered male perspectives, rendering women invisible even in their own representations.² Morisot challenges this by offering a distinct visual language, one shaped by an understanding of how women view and are viewed.

The wall label accompanying the painting quotes Jacques-Emile Blanche, who observed Morisot at work. While informative, the label privileges a male contemporary's voice over Morisot's. It lacks discussion of the cultural or gendered significance of the painting or Morisot's position as a female artist navigating a male-dominated field. By focusing on anecdote and painterly technique, the label misses how *The Pink Dress* contributes to a broader redefinition of femininity and subjectivity, key concerns for women Impressionists often sidelined in art history.

² Nochlin, Linda, "Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?" (1971), In *Women, Art, and Power, and other essays* (New York: Harper & Row, 1988), p 145

Inside the gallery, themes of nature, family, and daily rituals emerge. *The Pink Dress* hangs near the entrance, adjacent to the room's main wall label, signaling its significance. Yet it is physically confined, surrounded by three still lifes by Henri Fantin-Latour: *Roses and Lilies* (1888), *Roses in a Bowl* (1883), and *Asters and Fruit on a Table* (1868). These elegant works reinforce conventional links between femininity and beauty, stillness, and decoration. Morisot's portrait disrupts this pattern. She inserts a female figure into a similar domestic space, yet Marguerite is not an object of passive display; she is an active subject of interiority and self-awareness. However, this arrangement, Morisot's painting hemmed in by male-authored still lifes, unintentionally reflects the broader gender hierarchies that shaped both artistic production and institutional recognition.

Ultimately, *The Pink Dress* transforms a seemingly ordinary domestic scene into a nuanced meditation on gender, identity, and artistic authorship. Through Morisot's deliberate use of brushwork, spatial ambiguity, and symbolic color, the painting foregrounds a woman who is not a passive muse but an active subject. In contrast to the surrounding male-authored still lifes and traditional portrayals of women, Marguerite's calm self-possession and direct gaze assert a modern form of femininity: aware, expressive, and autonomous. Morisot's early masterpiece not only challenges the gendered limitations of her time but also offers a distinctly feminist revision of how women can be seen in art: not through the lens of the male gaze, but through a vision shaped by their presence, complexity, and quiet power.

Works Cited

Morisot Berthe. *The Pink Dress*(1870). The Metropolitan Museum of Art. New York.

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Nochlin, Linda, "Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?" (1971), In *Women, Art, and Power, and other essays* (New York: Harper & Row, 1988), p 145.